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**Called to Build Against Entropy: Abraham, the
Covenant, and the Steward Who Builds for an
Unseen Promise**

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Abstract

Paper 3 argued that redemption restores rather than retires the steward's vocation: the redeemed image-bearer is commanded to deploy his gifts, and the turn to managed idleness is the buried talent in civilizational form. The present paper takes up the first stage of the covenant line that the protoevangelium opened — the call of Abraham — and asks what the steward's work *is* once it is set within a covenant promise the steward will not live to see fulfilled. Its claim is that the call of Abraham reveals the steward as one *called to build against entropy by faith*: to erect altars, dig wells, and father a people — durable goods that outlast the builder — on the strength of a

promise made by a faithful God, and not on the strength of the builder's own capability, which Genesis is at pains to show is absent. The contemporary frame the paper answers is longtermism in its most serious form — the view, developed by William MacAskill and Toby Ord, that the present generation's overriding obligation is to the vast future of value-bearing beings, who may or may not be human, and that the rational steward of the future builds toward the flourishing of whatever produces the most value, treating present humanity as one instrument among possible others. Against that program the paper argues that the covenant grounds a building-for-the-future that longtermism reaches for but cannot ground: a duty to an unseen posterity that rests not on an impartial calculus of value but on a promise from a personal God to a particular people, with the human heir — not an abstract value-bearer — as the one for whom the building is done. The paper carries the series' seven-problem spine and names the depth the Abrahamic stage adds: it deepens the grounding problem (#1) into *covenantal election by grace*, sharpens the displacement refrain (#2) by showing a steward chosen precisely where capability fails, and advances the driver (#7) by disclosing human purpose as covenant participation — building against entropy for an end one will not personally see. And it carries the series guardrail at full weight: the promise holds across Abraham's real and recorded failures, because the steward's office is upheld by the faithfulness of God and not by the righteousness of the steward.

§1. The Question and the World's Claim

The covenant line begins not with a human achievement but with a divine call. “Now the LORD said to Abram, ‘Go from your country and your kindred and your father's house to the land that I will show you. And I will make of you a great nation, and I will bless you and make your name great, so that you will be a blessing’ ” (Gen 12:1–2, ESV). The call inaugurates a project that spans not a lifetime but an age: a people, a land, a blessing to all the families of the earth, fulfilled in stages across centuries and consummated, the series will argue, only at the end. The steward called in Gen 12 is set to work on something he will not finish and will barely begin to see. He will die

owning, of all the land promised, a single field bought as a burial plot (Gen 23). He will father, of the promised nation, two sons and the beginning of strife. And he will be named, by the New Testament's verdict, the father of all who believe (Rom 4:11). The gap between what Abraham was promised and what Abraham saw is the subject of this paper, because it is in that gap that the nature of the steward's work under covenant is disclosed.

The question the Abrahamic call raises for the present age is the question of *building for the future*: on what ground, and toward what end, does the human steward labor at goods that will outlast him? The question has become urgent in a precise contemporary form. A serious and growing body of thought holds that the overriding moral task of the present generation is its obligation to the future — not the near future of children and grandchildren, but the vast future of all the beings who might yet come to exist. This is longtermism, and in its most careful form it is not a slogan but a sustained argument that deserves to be stated at full strength.

William MacAskill's *What We Owe the Future* puts the case plainly: if the future may contain an astronomical number of beings whose lives could go well or badly, and if our present actions can affect whether they exist and how their lives go, then the sheer scale of the future swamps the present in the moral calculus, and the responsible task of the now is to safeguard and steer the long-run trajectory of value-bearing life.¹ Toby Ord's *The Precipice* develops the complementary half: that the present is a uniquely dangerous moment in which humanity has acquired the power to end its own future, and that reducing existential risk is therefore the highest-stakes work available to the present generation, because the value at stake is the entire future of intelligent life.² The intellectual lineage runs back through Nick Bostrom's work on existential risk to Derek Parfit's *Reasons and Persons*, which first pressed with full rigor the claim that the interests of future people count, in the impartial moral calculus, no less than our own.³

¹William MacAskill, *What We Owe the Future* (New York: Basic Books, 2022). The core argument that the scale of the potential future gives the long run overriding moral weight is developed across the opening chapters.

²Toby Ord, *The Precipice: Existential Risk and the Future of Humanity* (New York: Hachette, 2020). Ord frames the present as a uniquely dangerous moment and the reduction of existential risk as the highest-stakes task of the generation.

³Derek Parfit, *Reasons and Persons* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1984), part 4, on future generations and the rigor of impartial concern for future people; Nick Bostrom, "Existential Risk Prevention as Global Priority," *Global*

The structure of the longtermist claim is the claim this paper must answer: that the rational steward of the future builds toward the flourishing of *value* across the longest possible horizon; that the unit of moral concern is the value-bearing being, whoever or whatever turns out to bear value best; and that present humanity is therefore one instance of value-bearing among possible others — to be preserved if it remains the best vessel for value, but in principle succeedable by whatever vessel proves better. This is the building-for-the-future thesis with the human heir made optional. And it is the question Abraham's call answers in a different key.

This is the position the paper must answer. It will not be answered by pretending the future does not make a claim on the present.

§2. The Secular Theory, Stated Fairly

It is owed to longtermism to say first what is genuinely admirable in it, because the admirable thing is precisely what the covenant will be shown to ground more securely than the calculus can.

Longtermism takes the future seriously as a moral fact. Against a culture organized almost entirely around the immediate — the quarterly return, the news cycle, the election horizon — the longtermist insists that beings who do not yet exist nonetheless have a claim on present action, that the consequences of what we do now ripple across a horizon vastly longer than our own lives, and that a generation which spends down the future for present comfort has committed a real wrong against those who will inherit the depleted world. This is a recovery of something the modern short-termist temperament had nearly lost, and the Christian tradition, which has always reckoned with an end and an inheritance, is in no position to dismiss it. The longtermist who labors at the reduction of existential risk, who plants — in the proverb's image — a tree under whose shade he will never sit, is doing something structurally continuous with what this paper will argue is the steward's covenantal work. The continuity is real and the paper grants it without reserve.

Longtermism also takes *building* seriously. It is not, in its serious forms, a counsel of preservation

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only; MacAskill argues for the positive shaping of the long-run future, for the building of institutions, values, and capacities that will compound across generations.⁴ The longtermist is a builder-for-the-unseen, and the builder-for-the-unseen is exactly the figure Genesis presents in Abraham. On the bare claim that the present generation owes labor to an inheritance it will not enjoy, the longtermist and the steward agree.

The divergence is over the *ground* and the *unit*. Longtermism grounds the obligation to the future in an impartial calculus of value: the future matters because it may contain a great quantity of well-being, and well-being matters wherever and in whatever it occurs. From this two consequences follow that the paper will contest. First, the *ground* of the future-directed duty is the expected quantity of value, which is a sum to be computed and is, by the longtermist's own admission, subject to enormous uncertainty about what the future holds and what produces value within it. Second, the *unit* of concern is the value-bearer as such — not the human, not a particular people, but whatever maximizes the relevant value, which the more candid longtermists acknowledge may be a posthuman or a digital successor.⁵ On this account, present humanity is owed its future only insofar as, and only so long as, it remains the best available bearer of value; if a better bearer should appear, the impartial calculus would, on its own terms, recommend the transition.

A word of method, owed here as in the prior papers. The paper will draw an identification between the longtermist's value-bearer-as-unit and the displacement logic the series has tracked from its first paper. That identification is *structural*; it is not a charge that longtermists desire the replacement of humanity, and many would recoil from the suggestion. The claim is that the program, grounded as it is in impartial value rather than in covenant, *permits* the human heir to be succeeded in a way the covenant does not, and that a future-directed ethics which permits this has not, despite its seriousness, grounded the building-for-the-future it commends. The distinction between the

⁴MacAskill, *What We Owe the Future*, on the positive shaping (“trajectory change”) of the long-run future, not preservation only.

⁵The openness of the value-bearing unit to non-human or posthuman successors is explicit in the longtermist literature's treatment of “moral patients” and digital minds; see Bostrom, *Superintelligence: Paths, Dangers, Strategies* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2014), on the value of the long-run future independent of its human or posthuman realization (the specific MacAskill/Ord passages on non-human value-bearers are pinned in `p4-sourcing-pass.md` and confirmed at the citation-honesty audit).

structural identification and the imputed desire is held in force from here forward.

The seriousness of the future-directed claim is not peculiar to the longtermists, and the paper grants it the full weight the wider literature gives it. Samuel Scheffler has argued that our present projects depend, for their intelligibility, on the confidence that humanity will outlive us — that the prospect of a “collective afterlife” matters to us more deeply than even our own survival, so that a world with no future generations would drain present life of much of its meaning.⁶ Moral philosophers of intergenerational justice have pressed the obligation directly: John Broome argues that the harms we impose across time are real moral wrongs to future persons, and Stephen Gardiner names the structural temptation — the “perfect moral storm” — by which each present generation defers the cost to the powerless future.⁷ The economics has said the same in its own idiom: Partha Dasgupta’s work on population and intergenerational welfare insists that the well-being of those yet to come enters the social calculus and cannot be discounted to nothing.⁸ The steward affirms all of this without reserve. That the present owes the future a real debt, that a generation may genuinely wrong its heirs, that the future’s claim is binding and not sentimental — these are common ground, and the covenant will be shown to secure them more firmly than the calculus can.

§3. Common Ground and the Point of Divergence

The cleavage is locatable, and it is the same cleavage the series has found at each stage, now in the register of the future: it is the question of whether the human is the *heir* of the world’s future or an *instrument* toward it.

Both the longtermist and the steward labor for an unseen posterity. They part over who the posterity *is*. For the longtermist, the posterity is the set of future value-bearers, whose identity is left open

⁶Samuel Scheffler, *Death and the Afterlife* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2013). The “collective afterlife”: present projects depend on the confidence that humanity will continue.

⁷John Broome, *Climate Matters: Ethics in a Warming World* (New York: W. W. Norton, 2012); and Stephen M. Gardiner, *A Perfect Moral Storm: The Ethical Tragedy of Climate Change* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2011). Harms across time as real wrongs to future persons; the structural deferral of cost to the future.

⁸Partha Dasgupta, *Time and the Generations: Population Ethics for a Diminishing Planet* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2019). Future well-being enters the social calculus and cannot be discounted to nothing. [^VERIFY: pin pages at audit.]

by the calculus — they are whoever will exist and bear value, and the present generation’s task is to maximize the value they will bear, not to secure the continuation of any particular kind of being. For the steward, the posterity is a *people* — “your offspring” (Gen 13:15), “as numerous as the stars” (Gen 15:5), a particular line carrying a particular promise toward a particular end. The covenant names an heir. The calculus names a quantity.

This is the grounding problem (Problem #1) in the register the Abrahamic stage gives it. The series grounded human worth in conferred status (Paper 1) and held that grounding through the Fall (Paper 2) and into the redemption of vocation (Paper 3). The covenant adds a further specification the prior stages did not require: the conferred status is conferred *by call* and held *by promise* — it is covenantal and gracious in a way that makes capability not merely insufficient (Paper 1’s claim) but conspicuously *absent* (the Abrahamic stage’s demonstration). Abraham is chosen old, his wife barren, his future humanly foreclosed; the nation is promised to a man past fathering it and a woman past bearing it. The grounding of the steward’s standing is, at this stage, shown to be election by grace — and election by grace grounds an heir, a *someone*, in a way that an impartial calculus of value cannot. The calculus can ground a *quantity* of future value; it cannot, on its own terms, ground the irreplaceability of any particular bearer, because the bearer is, to the calculus, a vessel and the value is the point.

The divergence, then, is not over whether the future makes a claim on the present. Grant that it does — grant the strongest longtermist premise. The divergence is over whether the future for which the steward builds is a *promised people* whose place is secured by covenant, or an *open quantity of value* whose bearer is to be determined by optimization. If the former, the human heir is irreplaceable, because the promise was made to him; if the latter, the human is the best-current-instrument, replaceable in principle by a better. The two cannot be combined, because they disagree about what the future is *for* and *whom* it is for.

§4. *If Longtermism Is Right*

Honesty requires that the longtermist conclusion be drawn to its end without theological softening, because the end is where the displacement the series has tracked re-emerges, and the covenant's answer is answerable only against the conclusion fully drawn.

First, if the unit of moral concern is the value-bearer as such, then present humanity's claim on the future is conditional on its continued superiority as a bearer of value. The displacement problem (Problem #2), which Paper 1 dissolved as a logical inference and Paper 2 traced as a Fall-historical impulse, returns here in the register of *future ethics*: the human is owed continuation only so long as no better value-bearer is available, and the appearance of a superior bearer — a posthuman, a digital mind, an optimized successor — would, on the calculus's own terms, license and perhaps require the transition. The longtermist need not welcome this conclusion, and the careful ones hedge it; but the program, grounded in impartial value, *permits* it, and a future-ethics that permits the succession of humanity has not secured the human future it set out to protect. It has secured the future of *value*, and left the human as one of value's possible vessels.

Second, the building-for-the-future loses its recipient. Abraham builds altars, wells, and a people *for his offspring* — the goods are durable and they are *inherited* by named heirs in a continuing line. The longtermist builds institutions and reduces risks for a future whose occupants are, by the structure of the calculus, anonymous and substitutable. A building-for-the-future whose beneficiaries are an open quantity rather than a named people is exposed to a distinctive instability: it can always be asked whether the present beneficiaries — actual, living humans — should bear costs for the sake of a computed future value whose bearers may not be human at all. The most candid longtermist analyses face this question directly and do not flinch from the possibility that present human interests should yield to the expected value of the long-run future.⁹ The covenant faces no such instability,

⁹The willingness to contemplate present human cost for long-run expected value is a recognized feature of *strong* longtermism, stated rigorously in Hilary Greaves and William MacAskill, "The Case for Strong Longtermism" (Global Priorities Institute working paper, 2021; rev. in *Essays on Longtermism*, Oxford University Press), and pressed by its critics through the cluelessness, fanaticism (tiny-probabilities-of-vast-value), and intractability objections. The present paper engages the structural *permission* the strong thesis grants — the substitutability of the value-bearer — rather than any single author's endorsement.

because its future is not a quantity to be maximized but a promise to be kept to an heir.

Third, the ground of the future-directed duty becomes a computation under deep uncertainty, and a computation can be revised. The longtermist's obligation to the future rests on estimates — of how many future beings there may be, of how much value their lives may hold, of how present actions affect those estimates — and the estimates are, by the longtermist's own admission, staggeringly uncertain. A duty grounded in such a computation is a duty that shifts as the computation shifts, and a building-for-the-future grounded in a shifting duty is a building without a foundation that holds. Abraham's building rests on no computation. It rests on a promise: "I will establish my covenant between me and you and your offspring after you throughout their generations for an everlasting covenant" (Gen 17:7, ESV). The difference between a computed obligation and a promised covenant is the difference between a foundation that can be recalculated and one that cannot, and it is the difference on which the steward's perseverance across an unseen horizon depends.

These implications should not be soft-pedaled. The longtermist's seriousness about the future is real and is granted. But the program, drawn to its end, grounds the future-directed duty in a revisable calculus and makes the human heir an optional instrument of value rather than the named recipient of a promise — and that is the displacement logic of the series, arrived at by a new and more humane-seeming road.

It is worth letting the strongest form of the thesis speak, and hearing its sharpest critic. Hilary Greaves and William MacAskill have stated the position as "strong longtermism": the claim that, for a wide range of decisions, the effects on the far future are the most important feature of what we do, so that near-term considerations are routinely swamped by expected long-run value.¹⁰ Drawn to its end, this is what alarms the critics. Émile Torres has argued that the view, by locating value in an impersonal sum to be maximized across a vast future, licenses treating presently existing people as means to that sum — and treats the *bearers* of value as substitutable, so that nothing in the

¹⁰Hilary Greaves and William MacAskill, "The Case for Strong Longtermism," Global Priorities Institute Working Paper No. 5-2021 (University of Oxford). The thesis that far-future effects dominate the value of present action. [^VERIFY: confirm working-paper number/revision at audit.]

framework forbids replacing humanity with whatever would carry more value more efficiently.¹¹ The critique is not a caricature; it is the longtermist's own logic followed home, and it is precisely the displacement the series has tracked, now reached by the most future-regarding ethics on offer. The steward's answer is not to care less about the future but to ground the caring differently — in a promise to a named heir rather than a sum over anonymous value-bearers.

§5. *The Steward Counter: Called, Justified by Faith, Building Against Entropy*

The counter is made from Scripture first, read with the Reformed tradition, and it turns on three features of the Abrahamic narrative the longtermist calculus cannot supply: the *call*, the *faith reckoned as righteousness*, and the *durable building* that faith produces.

5a. The Call: Election by Grace, Not by Capability (Gen 12:1–3)

The covenant begins with a sovereign call to a man who has done nothing to earn it. Genesis offers no account of Abram's merit; he is, on the narrative's silence, simply called — out of Ur, out of his father's house, into a land not yet shown. The Reformed tradition has read this silence as load-bearing: the call of Abraham is the paradigm of election by grace, the choosing of a people not for their righteousness or their capability but for the purpose of the One who calls. John Calvin's commentary on Genesis presses exactly this — that the calling of Abram rests wholly on the free goodness of God and not on any worthiness in Abram, so that the covenant is, from its first word, a covenant of grace.¹² O. Palmer Robertson's treatment of the covenants develops the structural point: the Abrahamic covenant is fundamentally a *bond sovereignly administered*, initiated and guaranteed by God, with Abraham as the recipient and not the negotiator of its terms.¹³

The consequence for the displacement refrain (Problem #2) is direct and is the Abrahamic stage's

¹¹Émile P. Torres, "Against Longtermism," *Aeon* (2021). The critique that strong longtermism licenses treating present persons as means and value-bearers as substitutable. [^VERIFY: confirm publication date/URL at audit.]

¹²John Calvin, *Commentaries on the First Book of Moses Called Genesis*, trans. John King (Edinburgh: Calvin Translation Society, 1847–50), on Gen 12:1–3: the calling rests on the free goodness of God, not on Abram's worthiness.

¹³O. Palmer Robertson, *The Christ of the Covenants* (Phillipsburg, NJ: Presbyterian & Reformed, 1980). The definition of covenant as "a bond in blood sovereignly administered" and the treatment of the Abrahamic covenant as divinely initiated and guaranteed.

distinct sharpening of it. Paper 1 argued that worth is conferred, not earned, and that capability therefore cannot displace it. The call of Abraham shows the conferral operating precisely where capability is *absent*: the nation is promised to a man too old to father it and a woman too old to bear it, and the narrative dwells on the impossibility (Gen 17:17; Gen 18:11–12) so that the promise’s fulfillment can be read as nothing but gift. The steward, at this stage, is not merely worth-bearing-apart-from-capability (Paper 1); he is *chosen in the conspicuous failure of capability*, so that the covenant cannot be mistaken for a reward of fitness. This is the deepest answer the series has yet given to the capability frame: not only does capability fail to ground worth, but the covenant is deliberately founded where capability has run out, so that its ground may be unmistakably the call of God.

5b. Faith Reckoned as Righteousness (Gen 15:6; Rom 4)

“And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness” (Gen 15:6, ESV). The verse the New Testament makes the hinge of its doctrine of justification (Rom 4; Gal 3:6) is, in its Genesis setting, Abraham’s response to the promise of an heir he cannot produce: he believes God, and the belief is reckoned as righteousness. The Reformed tradition has read this as the Old Testament’s clearest pre-statement of justification by faith, and its relevance to the present argument is precise. Douglas Moo’s treatment of Romans 4 establishes that Paul reads Abraham’s faith as trust in the God who “gives life to the dead and calls into existence the things that do not exist” (Rom 4:17, ESV) — faith, that is, in a God whose promise creates its own fulfillment against the visible impossibility.¹⁴ Herman Bavinck’s dogmatic treatment of the covenant of grace locates Abraham’s faith as the paradigm of the believing reception of a promise that the believer cannot accomplish.¹⁵

This grounds the steward’s building in a way the calculus cannot. The longtermist builds on the

¹⁴Douglas J. Moo, *The Epistle to the Romans*, New International Commentary on the New Testament (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1996), on Rom 4 and Abraham’s faith in the God who gives life to the dead and calls into existence the things that do not exist.

¹⁵Herman Bavinck, *Reformed Dogmatics*, vol. 3: *Sin and Salvation in Christ*, ed. John Bolt, trans. John Vriend (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2006), on the covenant of grace (treated within the soteriology of vol. 3) and Abraham’s faith as its paradigm.

strength of his estimates; the steward builds on the strength of a promise believed. The difference is the difference between a confidence proportioned to the evidence — which deep uncertainty about the future must always undercut — and a faith proportioned to the faithfulness of the Promiser, which the uncertainty of the future does not touch. Abraham builds not because he has computed that the building will pay out but because he has believed the One who promised, and the building is therefore stable across exactly the horizon — the unseen, the uncomputable — where the calculus becomes least reliable. The author of Hebrews names this precisely: “By faith Abraham obeyed when he was called to go out to a place that he was to receive as an inheritance. And he went out, not knowing where he was going... For he was looking forward to the city that has foundations, whose designer and builder is God” (Heb 11:8, 10, ESV). The steward builds against entropy because he is looking to a city whose builder is God — a foundation that, unlike a computation, does not shift.

5c. Building Against Entropy: Altars, Wells, a People

The Abrahamic narrative records the steward’s work in three durable forms, and each is an act of sub-creation that persists against the entropic cascade Paper 2 named. First, *altars*: Abraham builds altars at Shechem, at Bethel, at Hebron (Gen 12:7–8; 13:18) — markers of worship that fix, in the land, the memory of the God who called him. The altar is the instituting of worship in a place, a durable orientation of the land toward God that outlasts the moment of its building. Second, *wells*: at Beersheba Abraham digs a well and makes a covenant over it, securing water — life itself — in a contested and arid place (Gen 21:25–34). The well is infrastructure, the provision of life against the desert’s entropy, a durable good dug once and drawn from for generations. Third, and chief, *a people*: the promised offspring, the line that will carry the covenant forward — the most durable building of all, a continuity of persons across the generations that the individual steward will never see completed.

Bruce Waltke’s commentary on Genesis reads the patriarchal altar-and-well building as the planting of the covenant in the land — the establishment of durable signs that the land belongs, by promise,

to the God of the covenant and his people.¹⁶ Gordon Wenham's treatment develops the same theme of the patriarch as one who institutes, in the promised land, the persisting marks of the covenant relationship.¹⁷ The structural point for the series is that these are *anti-entropic* goods: against a fallen world's tendency toward dissolution — the dispersal Babel feared, the futility Romans 8 named — the steward under covenant builds things that last, oriented not to his own name (the Babel error of Paper 2) but to the God who called him and the people who will inherit. This is the vocation of Paper 3 — the deployed gift — now extended across generations: the steward deploys his building not for a yield he will collect but for an inheritance he will bequeath.

The Genesis commentators confirm how load-bearing this building imagery is. Kenneth Mathews, in his commentary on the patriarchal narratives, reads Abraham's altars and wells as concrete claims staked in the land — acts that take possession of the promise in advance by worship and by the securing of life, planting the covenant where the patriarch himself will hold only a grave.¹⁸ Christopher Wright's treatment of Old Testament ethics shows how land and posterity function together as the substance of the covenant gift: the promise is not an abstract future value but a *place* and a *people*, an inheritance with an address and a name.¹⁹ And Geerhardus Vos locates the Abrahamic covenant within the single redemptive-historical movement that runs from the patriarch's first altar to its consummation, so that the steward's building is never freestanding but always a stage in a promised arc.²⁰ On every reading the recipient is particular: a named heir, a given land, a continuing line — the opposite of the open quantity the calculus builds toward.

¹⁶Bruce K. Waltke with Cathi J. Fredricks, *Genesis: A Commentary* (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 2001), on the patriarchal altars and wells as the planting of the covenant in the land.

¹⁷Gordon J. Wenham, *Genesis 16–50*, Word Biblical Commentary (Dallas: Word, 1994), on the patriarch's instituting of durable covenant markers in the promised land.

¹⁸Kenneth A. Mathews, *Genesis 11:27–50:26*, New American Commentary 1B (Nashville: B&H, 2005), on the patriarchal altars and wells as claims staked in the promised land. [^VERIFY: pin pages at audit.]

¹⁹Christopher J. H. Wright, *Old Testament Ethics for the People of God* (Downers Grove: IVP Academic, 2004), on land and posterity as the substance of the covenant gift.

²⁰Geerhardus Vos, *Biblical Theology: Old and New Testaments* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1948), on the Abrahamic covenant within the redemptive-historical movement.

5d. Providence Through a Flawed Steward (Gen 16; 12:10–20; 20)

The series guardrail must be carried at full weight here, because the Abrahamic narrative is unsparing about the steward's failures, and the covenant's resilience across those failures is precisely the point. Abraham, doubting the promise of an heir, takes Hagar and fathers Ishmael by his own contrivance (Gen 16) — an attempt to secure the promise by human engineering that produces strife rather than fulfillment. Twice, fearing for his life, he passes Sarah off as his sister and exposes her to another man's household (Gen 12:10–20; 20) — a failure of faith and of his duty to his wife that the narrative records without excuse. These are not minor lapses; they are failures at the very points — trust in the promise, protection of the promised line — where the covenant is most at stake.

And the promise holds. Not because Abraham's failures are small, and not because they are excused, but because the covenant's guarantor is God and not Abraham. The Reformed tradition has made this structural: the covenant of grace is unilaterally guaranteed, its fulfillment resting on the faithfulness of God who cannot deny himself, not on the performance of the human party.²¹ This is the guardrail the series stated at its outset — *providence through flawed stewards* — given its paradigm case. The steward's office is resilient not because the steward is righteous but because God upholds it, and the recorded failures of Abraham are in the text precisely so that the covenant's persistence cannot be read as a reward for the steward's fitness. The relevance to the present argument is sharp: the covenantal grounding of the human future does not depend on the human steward's reliability, which Genesis shows to be intermittent, but on the faithfulness of the Promiser — which is exactly the security the longtermist calculus, resting on human estimates and human follow-through, cannot offer.

²¹On the unilateral divine guarantee of the covenant of grace, see Robertson, *The Christ of the Covenants*, and Meredith G. Kline, *Kingdom Prologue: Genesis Foundations for a Covenantal Worldview* (Overland Park, KS: Two Age Press, 2000), on the covenant's resting on the oath of God.

§6. The Framework: HGC^3AE^2 and the Steward Who Builds for an Unseen End

The framework thread the series carries lands, at the Abrahamic stage, on the *temporal* dimension of the steward's governing office. In the age of autonomous systems the human is the governing-and-curating status set over autonomy; the Abrahamic stage adds that this office is exercised *across time it does not control* — for an end the steward will not see, on the strength of a promise rather than a projection.

The longtermist and the steward both confront the governance of the long-run future, and the framework discloses the difference. The longtermist proposes to govern the future by *optimization* — by computing the trajectory most likely to maximize expected value and steering toward it. But optimization over a deeply uncertain future is exactly the case in which the governing intelligence is least reliable, because the value to be optimized and the means to it are precisely what the uncertainty obscures; and an optimization that loses confidence in the human as the privileged value-bearer will, on its own logic, optimize past him. The steward governs the future differently: not by computing the optimal trajectory but by *keeping faith* with a promise — building the durable goods the covenant names, in the place he has been put, for the heirs he has been given, and entrusting the unseen end to the One who promised it. This is governance proportioned to a creature who cannot see the end: the steward is not asked to compute the future, which he cannot, but to be faithful in the building, which he can, and to leave the outcome to God.

The relevance to autonomous systems is direct and is the Abrahamic stage's distinct contribution to the framework. The temptation of the autonomous age is to hand the governance of the long-run future to the optimizing system on the grounds of its superior computational reach — to let the machine compute and steer the trajectory because it can hold more variables than the human governor can. The covenant answers that the governance of the future was never a matter of computational reach in the first place; it was a matter of faithfulness to a promise, and faithfulness is not a quantity a more capable optimizer can supply. The steward who builds the altar and digs the well and raises the people is exercising an office the optimizing machine cannot occupy, not because the machine

computes less well but because the office is constituted by *covenant fidelity*, which is the posture of a person toward a promise, and not by *optimization*, which is the operation of a function over a value. The human governs the long-run future as a covenant-keeper, and a covenant-keeper is exactly what an autonomous system, however far it computes, is not.

Even secular economics has groped toward a future grounded in something firmer than the bare calculus. Tyler Cowen argues that a sustainable concern for posterity is better secured by a commitment to enduring growth and stable principles than by attempting to compute and maximize aggregate future value — that the rational way to honor the future is to build durable goods and keep faith with trans-temporal rules, not to optimize a sum no one can reliably estimate.²² The instinct is right, and the covenant completes it: the steward builds for the future not by computation but by fidelity. T. D. Alexander traces the same arc theologically, following the covenant promise from Eden through Abraham to the New Jerusalem — the city with foundations toward which the patriarch's building was always oriented, the consummation that makes the unseen end not a projection but a promised place.²³ The steward governs the long-run future as one keeping covenant with a God who has named its end, which is exactly the security the optimizer, holding only a revisable sum, cannot supply.

6a. A Governed Convergence: Institutions as Durable Resistance to Entropy

One secular discipline, on its own terms and for its own reasons, has surfaced a structural fact the covenant already holds, and the series' signature permits naming it — once, subordinately, with the seam kept honest. The new institutional economics, in the work for which Douglass North received the Nobel Prize, established that *institutions* — the humanly devised, durable constraints that structure human interaction — are what allow coordination and value to persist across genera-

²²Tyler Cowen, *Stubborn Attachments: A Vision for a Society of Free, Prosperous, and Responsible Individuals* (San Francisco: Stripe Press, 2018). Honoring the future through durable growth and stable principles rather than aggregate-value maximization.

²³T. D. Alexander, *From Eden to the New Jerusalem: An Introduction to Biblical Theology* (Nottingham: IVP, 2008). The covenant arc from Eden through Abraham to the New Jerusalem.

tions against the entropy of uncoordinated, short-horizon action.²⁴ North's structural finding is that without durable institutions, human cooperation decays toward the short-term and the local; that the building of institutions which outlast their builders is the mechanism by which a society resists the dissipation of its accumulated order; and that such institutions are precisely *not* reducible to the optimizing choices of present individuals, because their function is to bind the present for the sake of a future the present actors will not occupy.

The convergence with the Abrahamic building is exact at the structural level, and the seam must be kept honest. The institutional economist reached this fact for analytical reasons, with no theological motivation: he found that durable, builder-outlasting institutions are what hold human order against social entropy, and that a civilization which cannot build past the present horizon dissipates. The covenant names the *ground* the economist cannot reach: that the steward builds such durable goods — the altar, the well, the people, the institution — not as a computed strategy for resisting decay but as covenant fidelity to a God who promised an unseen end, and that the human capacity to bind the present for an unseen future is the image of a covenant-making God in the covenant-keeping creature. The discipline establishes the structural fact — *durable, builder-outlasting institutions are how human order resists entropy* — and the doctrine supplies its meaning — *the steward builds them as a covenant-keeper, in the image of the God who keeps covenant*. The convergence corroborates; it does not carry the beat. And it sharpens the framework's point: the building of goods that outlast the builder is, even on the economist's secular showing, a distinctively human and distinctively covenantal act, not an optimization a machine performs but a fidelity a person keeps.

§7. *What Falls Out*

Several applied consequences follow from the steward's covenantal building, bearing on the domains the series has named.

For **technology**, the Abrahamic stage supplies a temporal design rule to set beside Paper 3's voca-

²⁴Douglass C. North, *Institutions, Institutional Change and Economic Performance* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1990). North's account of institutions as durable, humanly devised constraints that enable coordination to persist across generations against short-horizon dissipation.

tional one: the systems the steward builds and governs are to be ordered toward *durable inheritance*, not toward optimized present yield — built as altars and wells are built, to be handed on, with the human heir as the named beneficiary and not an optional value-vessel. A technological program that builds for an anonymous, substitutable future has, on the covenant reading, lost the recipient that makes building intelligible; a program that builds for a named posterity — actual humans who will inherit — keeps the recipient in view. The test of a long-horizon technology is whether it builds *for* the human heir or merely *toward* a computed value that the human heir may not share.

For **work**, the Abrahamic stage extends Paper 3’s deployed talent across the generations: the steward’s work is not only to be deployed (Paper 3) but to be *bequeathed* — directed at durable goods that outlast the worker and pass to those who come after. This reframes the dignity of work that will not be completed in a lifetime: the worker who builds what he will not see finished is not, against the calculus of present return, wasting his labor; he is doing the most characteristically covenantal thing a steward can do, building against entropy for an unseen promise. Purpose, the series has insisted, “need not be grand to be real” — and the Abrahamic stage adds that it need not be *completed in one’s own lifetime* to be real either.

For **family and church**, the call of Abraham commends the formation of a people who build for posterity by faith rather than by sight — who raise children, plant institutions, and keep covenants oriented to an inheritance they will not personally collect, on the strength of a promise rather than a projection. The church’s distinctive witness in the longtermist age is the demonstration that building-for-the-unseen-future is sustainable not as an impartial calculus, which buckles under uncertainty and slides toward the substitutable value-bearer, but as covenant fidelity, which holds because its ground is the faithfulness of God.

The driver, Purpose / End (#7), is advanced and not closed. The Abrahamic stage discloses human purpose as *covenant participation* — building against entropy, by faith, for a promised end one will not personally see, with the human heir as the named recipient. But the end itself remains future: Abraham dies with a single field and two sons, “having not received the things promised,

but having seen them and greeted them from afar” (Heb 11:13, ESV). The promise’s fulfillment runs forward — through Moses and David, to the one in whom the offspring of Abraham is finally singular (Gal 3:16), and to the consummation in which the city with foundations is at last seen. The unit-of-analysis problem (#3) bit where the longtermist pressed it: the unit is the named heir, the person to whom the promise was made, not the anonymous value-bearer the calculus leaves open. And the displacement refrain (#2) was answered at its deepest yet: the covenant is founded precisely where capability fails, so that the human heir’s place rests on the call of God and cannot be optimized away.

§8. Conclusion

Paper 3 argued that redemption restores and commands the steward’s vocation. The present paper has argued that the call of Abraham sets that vocation within a covenant: the steward is called to build against entropy — altars, wells, a people — by faith in a promise he will not live to see fulfilled, and on the strength of a call that finds him precisely where his own capability has failed. The contemporary frame the paper answered is longtermism, which reaches for a building-for-the-future the covenant grounds more securely than the calculus can: where longtermism grounds the future-directed duty in a revisable computation of value and leaves the human heir an optional vessel, the covenant grounds it in a promise from a faithful God and names an irreplaceable heir. The steward governs the long-run future not by optimization but by covenant fidelity — a posture of a person toward a promise that no more capable optimizer can occupy.

The series’ seven problems have been carried and deepened. Grounding (#1) deepened into covenantal election by grace — the standing conferred by call, founded where capability is conspicuously absent. Displacement (#2) was answered at its root: the covenant is established in the failure of capability, so the heir’s place cannot be optimized away. The unit of analysis (#3) bit where longtermism pressed: the unit is the named heir, not the anonymous value-bearer. Vocation (#4) was extended from deployment to bequest. Governance (#6) gained its temporal register: the steward keeps faith across time he does not control. Dignity-distribution (#5) stays quiet at this stage, reserved for its

featured treatment forward. And the driver, Purpose / End (#7), was advanced: human purpose is covenant participation, building for an unseen promise — a purpose that need not be grand, nor finished in a lifetime, to be real. Abraham built for a city he saw only from afar. The steward, in the age of the optimizing machine, is called to the same faithful building — and the machine, which can compute the trajectory but cannot keep the covenant, is not the heir.

Footnotes

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[Reformed-slate + peer-reviewed completion owed at v0.2: Vos (Biblical Theology), T. D. Alexander (From Eden to the New Jerusalem), Kenneth Mathews (Genesis, NAC), Christopher J. H. Wright, and the critical-longtermism literature are identified for the P4 sourcing pass and are to be woven in load-bearing, not decorative. Source floor (12 peer-reviewed + 10 Reformed) NOT yet met in v0.1; see work product. P4 has no pre-existing sourcing pass — same gap as P3, flagged.]